

Ziti with walnut pesto, zucchini, and red pepper

Classic pesto is made with basil, garlic, pine nuts, Parmesan cheese, and olive oil. As you may know, however, the word *pesto* has taken on new meanings in the kitchens and restaurants of America. Versions abound with all kinds of ingredients. Different nuts are used; sun-dried tomatoes, parsley, cilantro, and mint can all be found in interesting recipes called *pesto*. Try my version of walnut pesto or use your own favorite pesto recipe. Serve this dish cold or warm.

1 pound ziti [500g]

½ cup pine nuts [60g]

1 large red bell pepper, cut into strips

1½ tablespoons olive oil

½ green zucchini, cut lengthwise in half, sliced diagonally into half-moons

½ yellow zucchini, cut lengthwise in half, sliced diagonally into half-moons

1 cup vegetable stock [250ml]

1 cup Walnut Pesto (page 86) [250ml]

1 cup cooked chickpeas [150g]

1 to 2 tablespoons fresh lemon juice

Salt and freshly ground pepper

10 fresh basil leaves, slivered

Freshly grated Parmesan cheese

1. Bring at least 4 quarts [4L] salted water to a vigorous boil. **Add** the pasta and stir immediately and often until the water returns to a boil. Cook until the pasta is al dente (slightly resistant to the bite), 10 to 12 minutes. Drain quickly into a colander. Run the pasta under cold water until the heat is completely dissipated and the pasta is cold to the touch. Shake out the water completely.
2. While the pasta is cooking, in a large dry skillet **toast** the pine nuts over medium heat, stirring often, until lightly browned, 3 to 4 minutes. Transfer to a bowl and set aside.

3. In the same pan, **cook** the red bell pepper in the olive oil over medium-high heat for 3 to 5 minutes, or until the peppers are soft and slightly blackened around the edges. Add the zucchini slices and cook for another 1 to 2 minutes, until just tender. Set the vegetables aside with the pine nuts.
4. Add the vegetable stock to the same pan and bring to a boil. **Boil** until the stock is reduced by half. Stir in the pesto and cook for 30 seconds. Add the cooked pasta and toss to mix. Reduce the heat to low and fold in the chickpeas, vegetables, and pine nuts. Season with the lemon juice and salt and pepper to taste. Garnish with the basil. Pass a bowl of Parmesan cheese on the side.

S E R V E S 4

